

"EACH ONE SHOULD USE WHATEVER GIFT HE HAS RECEIVED TO SERVE OTHERS."—**1 PETER 4:10**

SUPPORT LEADERS

The people behind the welcome, care, and connection

Support Leader Handbook · 2026–2027

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01

SECTION 01

MISSION + MANTRAS

The GPS that keeps every ministry effort on course.

WHO WE ARE

As members of the body of Christ, we seek Great Commission and Great Commandment living **(Matt. 22:37–40 · Matt. 28:18–20).**

As members of this local body of Christ called Southeast, we seek to live this way through connecting people to Jesus and one another, utilizing some metaphors based on the life of Christ to keep us focused.

You, as a Support Leader in Student Ministry, are a culture carrier of our Mission and Mantras. You should frequently use them as a GPS to keep our ministry efforts focused on accomplishing Great Commission and Great Commandment living.

WHO WE ARE

MISSION + MANTRAS

MISSION

CONNECTING

PEOPLE

TO JESUS

AND

ONE ANOTHER

VISION

TO UNLEASH

THE FULL FORCE

OF THE CHURCH

TO LOVE PEOPLE

ONE AT A TIME

METAPHORS FROM THE LIFE OF CHRIST

BE THE BRANCH (JOHN 15:1–17)

We connect in community.
We value connection *to* Jesus over production *for* Jesus.

CATCH THE WIND (JOHN 3:1–8)

We connect the full force of the church with the Holy Spirit.
We value risk and adventure over safety and comfort.

WRECK THE ROOF (LUKE 5:18–25)

We will radically love people one at a time.
We value innovation over tradition.

GRIP THE PLOW (LUKE 9:57–62)

We serve with intentional and focused effort.
We value personal engagement over attendance.

EMPTY THE JAR (LUKE 7:36–50)

We connect through sacrificial generosity.
We value expressive worship over religious rituals.

LEADER CULTURE

LUKE 9 RHYTHMS

Five rhythms for leader culture, and the tools we use to live them based on the Luke 9 ministry team.

COMMUNITY	*"Jesus called the twelve together..."* **Luke 9:1a**	→ **HANGOUTS** → **HUDDLES** → **TEAM MEETINGS**
EQUIPPING	*"He gave them power and authority..."* **Luke 9:1b**	→ **UNLEASHED LEADERS** → **BIG 3** → **TRAINING**
MISSION	*"He sent them out..."* **Luke 9:2**	→ **WELCOME NEW STUDENTS** → **CONNECT THE UNCONNECTED**
CARE	*"They all ate and were satisfied..."* **Luke 9:17**	→ **TEAM LEADERS** → **SHEPHERDING**
RETREAT	*"Jesus was praying in private and his disciples were with him..."* **Luke 9:18**	→ **OVERNIGHTS** → **CELEBRATIONS**

02

SECTION 02

YOUR ROLE

What Support Leaders make possible.

YOU BELONG IN THIS MISSION

WELCOME, SUPPORT LEADER

We are so glad you are here! Every week, students walk into our ministries carrying different stories, questions, worries, and hopes. Some are excited to be here. Some are giving church a chance for the very first time. All of them matter to God.

Before a student ever joins a group or hears a message, someone opens a door, learns a name, helps them find their place, notices a need, protects the environment or prays for what God might do. **That someone might be you.**

Support Leaders are not simply helping ministry happen. **You are doing ministry.**

Your faithfulness helps create the kind of environment where students can encounter Jesus and build relationships that last. You are part of one Student Ministry team. We are so grateful for you, and we want you to feel confident about why we serve, what your role makes possible and how to serve well.

THANK YOU!
YOUR STUDENT MINISTRY TEAM

ROLE OVERVIEW

STAFF

- Shepherding Team Leaders
- Keeping the whole ministry on mission
- Being examples to the flock **1 Peter 5:2–4**
- Equipping Team Leaders

TEAM LEADER

- Shepherding a team of leaders
- Keeping your team focused on the mission
- Setting the pace for your teams
- Leading by example for your team **1 Cor. 11:1**

LEADER

- Shepherding students
- Initiating investment in a few
- Living out your spiritual gifts in the context of your team and the ministry in which you serve

SUPPORT LEADER

- Plugging new and unconnected students in
- Supporting ministry efforts
- Engaging students and families

THE HEART BEHIND SUPPORT

01 **Jesus' ministry didn't work without those around Him** LUKE 8:1–3

As Jesus went from town to town, a group of women traveled with Him, "helping to support them out of their own means." His ministry moved forward because people supported Him.

02 **Jesus is our model** MARK 10:42–45

The world measures greatness by who is in charge. Jesus flipped it: whoever wants to be great must serve. He came not to be served, but to serve and give His life.

03 **Shared work, growing church** ACTS 6:1–7

When needs outgrew the apostles, the early church chose faithful, Spirit-filled people to serve so the Word could keep going out—and the number of disciples grew. Support isn't secondary. It's how the mission multiplies.

04 **Every part matters** 1 CORINTHIANS 12:12–31

"Now you are the body of Christ, and each one of you is a part of it." No part gets all the attention, and no part can say it isn't needed. The person leading a group and the person running check-in both help students take a step closer to Jesus.

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

CHECK-IN

YOUR GOAL

Help every student begin the night with clarity, care, and confidence.

- **Offer a genuine greeting.** A calm, friendly welcome matters even when the line is long.
- Learn and follow the campus-approved check-in and attendance process; do not create unofficial shortcuts.
- Help new students know where to go next. When unsure, connect them with the designated Team Leader or Connections Leader.
- Protect student and family information. Keep screens, printed lists and conversations appropriately private.
- If a registration, pickup, attendance or access issue does not seem right, involve the designated Team Leader or staff member instead of guessing.

A SMALL WIN ***"You're in the right place. Let me help you get checked in."***

CONNECTIONS

YOUR GOAL

Help people move from arriving to belonging.

- Look for the first-time student, the student standing alone or the parent who seems unsure.
- Introduce yourself, learn names and ask simple questions before giving directions.
- Help students make a real connection with the appropriate Group Leader or Team Leader, rather than just pointing down a hallway.
- Pay attention to students who have visited before but still seem disconnected.
- Share relevant follow-up needs with the Team Leader through the approved process; do not independently collect or distribute student contact information.

A SMALL WIN ***"Have you met your leaders yet? I'd love to introduce you."***

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

SNACK BAR

YOUR GOAL

Turn a practical service into a welcoming point of connection.

- Prepare, serve, handle payments if applicable and clean up according to your campus's procedures.
- Be warm and attentive; a short interaction can make a student feel known.
- Keep stations clean and orderly and follow food safety procedures (wearing gloves while serving food, etc.).
- Look for opportunities to help rather than allow the station to become a distraction from students.

A SMALL WIN ***"Good to see you back! How has your week been?"***

SUPPORT TEAM

SECURITY

YOUR GOAL

Help provide an environment where students and leaders can focus on ministry because concerns are noticed and handled appropriately.

- Know your assigned area, responsibilities, communication method, and reporting contact.
- Stay observant and approachable; pay attention to entrances, transitions and anything outside the usual pattern.
- Follow established campus and church security procedures. Do not invent your own response or investigate concerning situations independently.
- Communicate concerns promptly and discreetly to designated security personnel and/or ministry staff.
- During an emergency, follow the approved emergency plan and the direction of authorized responders.

A SMALL WIN

A concern is recognized early, shared quickly and handled by the right people.

SUPPORT TEAM

PRAYER TEAM

YOUR GOAL

Intentionally cover the ministry in prayer and help people remember that God is at work.

- Pray before, during, and after ministry for students, Group Leaders, Support Leaders, families, and staff.
- Pray specifically for students who are new, hurting, disconnected or exploring faith, using only information appropriately shared with your team.
- When someone requests prayer: listen with care, ask what they would like prayer for and pray simply and sincerely.
- Respect personal boundaries and ministry guidelines; do not pressure someone to share, respond, or accept physical contact.
- If a conversation raises a significant pastoral or safety concern, involve ministry staff rather than trying to carry it alone.

A SMALL WIN ***"Would it be okay if I prayed with you?"***

3 WINS FOR SUPPORT LEADERS

THREE WINS

You may never teach a lesson or lead a small group. But the way you serve can shape whether a student feels comfortable enough to stay, connected enough to return and supported enough to take a next step.

01 **Students are seen and welcomed.**

A student is greeted, helped and treated like they matter...not like another name in a line. First impressions can become the beginning of belonging.

02 **Students are safe and cared for.**

Our spaces are attentive, orderly and responsive. We notice what is happening, honor boundaries, and involve the right people when a need arises.

03 **Students have room to connect with Jesus and others.**

When practical needs are met and distractions are addressed, students, Group Leaders and staff can focus on relationships, worship and discipleship. Prayer covers every part of the night.

WHERE YOU SERVE

TEAM

FIRST IMPRESSIONS

Check-In: Help students and families navigate the approved check-in process and get where they need to go.

Connections: Look for new or disconnected students and help them connect with a Group Leader, staff member, or next step.

Snack Bar: Offer warm, orderly hospitality through food and conversation while following campus procedures.

TEAM

SECURITY

Help maintain an attentive, welcoming environment through the assigned safety role, established procedures, and close communication with staff and designated security personnel.

TEAM

PRAYER TEAM

Pray intentionally for students, leaders, families, staff and the movement of God. Be available to pray with people when appropriate and connect significant care needs to ministry staff.

03

SECTION 03

SERVING WELL

Behind the scenes, every week. Prepare, pay attention and follow through.

EVERY SUPPORT LEADER

WHAT WE ASK

01 **Be faithful.**

Honor your serving commitment and communicate early when you cannot serve.

02 **Be ready.**

Arrive at your campus's designated time, know your assignment, and ask what you need to know before students arrive.

03 **Be present.**

Look up, engage people, and stay attentive instead of waiting for someone to tell you what to do.

04 **Be a teammate.**

Support Group Leaders, other Support Leaders, and staff. No task is beneath us.

05 **Model the way.**

Represent Jesus through your words, attitude, relationships, and choices.

06 **Ask for help.**

You are not expected to have every answer or solve every situation yourself.

A GOOD NIGHT **is not just "Did I complete my task?" It is also "Did I help someone take a step toward Jesus or toward community?"**

EVERY WEEK

THE RHYTHM OF A MINISTRY NIGHT

BEFORE

Prepare the space and your heart.

Arrive at your assigned time. Check in with your team lead or staff contact. Learn about special events, changes, or needs. Make sure your station is ready. Pray for the students and families who will walk through the doors.

DURING

Stay available to people.

Do your assigned job with excellence, but remember the person in front of you is more important than the process. Look for students who seem new, overwhelmed, alone or unsure of where to go. Stay in your assigned area unless your team lead directs otherwise.

AFTER

Leave the ministry stronger.

Finish assigned closing tasks, pass along any follow-up needs and communicate concerns to the right staff member. Make sure the next team has what it needs.

WHEN THE UNEXPECTED HAPPENS

01 **A student cannot find their group.**

Stay with the student as appropriate and connect them to the Connections Leader or Team Leader who can help.

02 **A parent has a question you cannot answer.**

Thank them for asking and introduce them to the Team Leader responsible for that decision.

03 **A student shares something concerning.**

Listen without making promises of secrecy. Bring in the appropriate staff member promptly, following established safety and reporting procedures.

04 **Something seems unsafe.**

Follow your campus's safety communication and emergency procedures right away. You do not need to determine whether a concern is serious enough on your own.

REMEMBER **Your job is to notice, care, connect, and communicate...not to fix everything.**

BE THE TEAMMATE YOU WISH YOU HAD

01 **Communicate early and clearly**

Especially if you cannot serve or something has changed.

02 **Assume the best**

Ask questions, and speak directly and kindly.

03 **Take responsibility**

Own your assignment and stay willing to help where you are needed.

04 **Protect trust**

Share sensitive student information only with appropriate ministry personnel who need it.

05 **Celebrate**

Celebrate what God is doing in other roles, not only the part you can see.

TEAM SPOTLIGHT · HSM WEDNESDAYS

COMMUNITY CREW

OUR MISSION

We set the stage for discipleship by helping every student feel seen, known, welcomed, and connected.

The assignment: Community Crew is our guest-experience team on steroids. We remove barriers, create energy, and make personal connections so students can engage with their group, their leaders, and Jesus.

01 **Arrive ready.**
Be on time for the volunteer gathering, know the plan and theme, receive your assignment, and pray with the team.

02 **Be fully present.**
Put your phone away except for ministry use. Stay attentive to students, leaders, entrances, and transitions.

03 **Move toward students first.**
Offer a warm greeting, learn and use names, ask good questions, and notice anyone who is new, alone, or uncertain.

04 **Own the handoff.**
Walk a student to the right group leader and make a personal introduction. Never simply point across the room.

05 **Protect the culture.**
Model appropriate boundaries, follow all student-safety policies, keep interactions visible, and promptly share concerns with ministry staff.

06 **Stay flexible and finish strong.**
Jump into needs without being asked, help reset the space, and share wins or follow-up needs before you leave.

COMMUNITY CREW

KEY ROLES

01 **Welcome Host**
Create a warm first moment at the entrances. Intentionally greet returning students and guests.

02 **Check-In Team**
Help students check in smoothly, answer basic questions, and spot first-time guests who need extra attention.

03 **“New Here” Team**
Learn the student’s name, introduce them to a group leader and a student peer, and stay until the connection is secure. Write a personal card to mail that week.

04 **Creative Experience Crew**
Lead theme-based welcome elements, games, giveaways, photo moments, or surprises that make the night memorable and fun.

05 **Connector**
Circulate, remember names and stories, reconnect from previous weeks, and help students move from attendance toward belonging.

06 **Room & Flow Support**
Prepare signs and supplies, reduce confusion, support transitions, and keep the environment inviting, safe, and ready.

A GREAT WEDNESDAY

Every student is greeted. New students are checked in and personally introduced. No one stands alone. Group leaders get clear handoffs. The room feels ready, safe, and fun.

You’re part of the team. Hangouts, camps, events, service projects, mission trips—you’re among the first we’ll invite. See another place to serve? Raise your hand and say “I’m in.”

04

SECTION 04

THE TEAM

Who you serve alongside—one team serving one mission.

HOW A GREAT HANDOFF WORKS

NOTICE

A ninth grader is standing alone and says they do not know anybody.

LISTEN

"I'm glad you came. Is this your first time?"

CONNECT

Walk with them to the right leader or staff member and make an introduction.

FOLLOW THROUGH

Let the appropriate leader know what might help the student feel welcomed next week.

The same principle applies to a concerned parent, a student requesting prayer, or a safety issue. Don't leave someone with only a direction when you can offer an appropriate connection.

WHAT YOU CAN EXPECT FROM STAFF

Staff should help you understand your assignment, connect you to the right team, provide role-specific training and ministry updates, and tell you where to bring questions or concerns. If you have not received the training or information you need, please ask before serving independently.

Same mission across every campus. Local processes may differ. Follow your campus's current instructions for team assignments, communications, student supervision, security, and emergencies.

05

SECTION 05

BIG THREE

MSM + HSM. Three times a year we gather all our Student Ministry leaders together.

ALL LEADERS · THREE TIMES A YEAR

THE BIG THREE

These are high priority events for our ministry. We expect you to be fully present.

The Big Three are also a pivotal part of our onboarding process for new leaders. Connected to each one, we host an **Unleashed Leader Training** for all new and potential leaders to on-ramp into our ministry—with flexibility for onboarding when we aren't near one of those planned starting points.

Your participation at each of these keystone moments is vital. We believe these moments together as a Student Ministry are foundational to keeping us aligned. **Put these dates on your calendar every year—and bring someone with you!**

EVENTS + TIPS

AUGUST
Leader Launch

Vision cast + launch into the new school year.

TIP

Lock in the date before summer. Know someone who'd make a great leader? Invite them to serve at camp—camp is the best on-ramp into the fall.

JANUARY
Leader Night

Reset + halftime speech for second semester.

TIP

Save the date in August, before the semester fills up. It's the reset you'll want for spring.

MAY
Leader Celebration

Celebrate all that God has done.

TIP

Save the date in January. Bring someone who's thinking about serving—it's a great first look at our team before camp.

PRECEDING EACH OF THE BIG THREE

UNLEASHED LEADERS (ALL YEAR)

Unleashed Leaders is a deep dive into our "why"—a training we expect every new leader to go through.

It sets up new leaders to learn who we are as a Student Ministry. Whether someone joins to lead a group or serve at check-in, they need to know our primary aim is to make disciples. We look at the life of Christ and allow it to inform how we approach ministry.

Since Jesus himself continually raised the bar for his disciples, we inform those joining us about the cost of following Jesus up front, so later they aren't surprised by what we ask of them. In some ways it can appear we are talking people out of doing ministry. In actuality, we are just echoing Jesus' call to make disciples—even some who heard it straight from Jesus' mouth chose not to follow.

We know things happen—but being up front about the commitment pays dividends when leaders know what they are signing up for and stick it out. Know someone who should serve with us? **Unleashed Leaders is their front door**—invite them and point them to the next one. **We love the community of leaders God has blessed us with. We get to fulfill Jesus' mission together!**

06

SECTION 06

FURTHER RESOURCES

Help along the way. You don't need to know everything—just when to ask, where to go, and how to hand off a need.

A SIMPLE CONVERSATION GUIDE



GREEN LIGHT

"Care and connect."

Everyday questions, nerves about joining a group, ordinary friendship challenges, or requests for prayer can often begin with a warm conversation. Listen, encourage, and help the student connect with a Group Leader or staff member when helpful.

YELLOW LIGHT

"Involve staff for guidance."

Ongoing bullying, significant family concerns, emotional distress, questions beyond your role, or other sensitive disclosures should be shared with a ministry staff member. Stay kind and calm; do not feel pressure to provide counseling or make a ministry decision on your own.

RED LIGHT

"Get help immediately."

Possible abuse, threats of harm, self-injury, serious safety concerns, a medical emergency, or a student in immediate danger require urgent help through the church's approved response and reporting procedures. Follow emergency directions and any applicable legal reporting requirements. Never promise absolute confidentiality.

YOUR WEEKLY QUICK CHECK

BEFORE

- [ ] Have I confirmed when and where to serve?
- [ ] Do I know my role, team lead, and any updates?
- [ ] Have I prayed for the students coming tonight?

DURING

- [ ] Am I approachable, attentive, and present?
- [ ] Have I welcomed someone by name or helped someone connect?
- [ ] Have I communicated any concerns to the right person?

AFTER

- [ ] Have I finished my station's closing tasks?
- [ ] Have I communicated follow-up needs?
- [ ] Have I confirmed my next serving date?

COMPLETE LOCALLY

CAMPUS QUICK REFERENCE

CAMPUS / MINISTRY _____

MINISTRY NIGHT & LOCATION _____

ARRIVAL / HUDDLE TIME _____

STUDENT MINISTRY STAFF CONTACT _____

SUPPORT TEAM LEAD _____

CHECK-IN / NEW STUDENT PROCESS _____

SECURITY TEAM LEADER & CONTACT _____

ANYTHING MISSING? _____

FOUR QUESTIONS

Four questions for every leader:

01 **How am I connecting to Jesus?**

Your relationship with Jesus matters more than the task you complete. Serve from time with Him, not as a substitute for time with Him.

02 **How am I connecting to one another?**

Ministry is a team effort. Know the people you serve with, encourage them, and build relationships that extend beyond your assignment.

03 **How am I connecting people to Jesus?**

A warm welcome, a calm response or an offered prayer can help remove an obstacle between a student and their next step toward Jesus.

04 **How am I connecting people to one another?**

Belonging often opens the door to deeper connection. Notice the student who is standing alone and help them find a person, a group, or a place to belong.

FAQ'S

QUESTIONS YOU MAY HAVE

Q **What if I can't serve one week?**

Communicate as early as possible using your campus's approved scheduling process. Do not assume your spot is covered until you have followed that process.

Q **What if I don't know the answer?**

It's okay to say, "That's a great question. Let me connect you with someone who can help."

Q **What if a student wants to talk about following Jesus or baptism?**

Celebrate their question and connect them with a Group Leader or ministry staff member who can walk through their next steps. Pray with them when appropriate.

Q **What if I notice a concern but I'm not sure how serious it is?**

Tell your designated staff or security contact promptly. It is better to communicate a concern than to carry it alone.

ONE STUDENT AT A TIME

One welcome.
One conversation.
One prayer.

A student's story can change through one conversation, one welcome, one moment of feeling safe, one invitation into community, or one prayer. The moments that feel small to us may be the moments God uses in a big way.

Thank you for helping connect students to Jesus and to one another.

SPACE TO THINK

NOTES

SPACE TO THINK

NOTES


Southeast
Students
CONNECTING PEOPLE TO JESUS & ONE ANOTHER